MOOD OF THE NATION POLL

FROM THE EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Remember the TIMO (There is Modi Only) factor that armour-plated Prime Minister Narendra Modi in his first decade? An unassailable moat, one that kept him way beyond the reach of any rivals. That aura was beginning to show signs of wear two years ago, after a decade in power. But thereafter, remarkably, his historic third term has seen Modi consistently improve his popularity rankings across four Mood of the Nation (MOTN) surveys *after* the 2024 Lok Sabha election. Asked about the personage "best suited to be next PM", he not only remains a clear No. 1, but his percentage score has also effectively reclaimed the old mid-50s plateau: from 49.1 in 2024, it now spikes up to 54.7. Crossmatch this with other key MOTN data, and the picture gathers further clarity, abolishing any trace of ambiguity. Strikingly, if a general election was held today, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) would win a comfortable majority of 287 seats on its own. That's an astonishing feat given that it won just 240 seats in the 2024 Lok Sabha election—32 short of a simple majority. The BJP's resurgence has seen the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) tally shoot to 352 seats, just one short of the highest tally it achieved in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls. Consequently, the Indian National Developmental and Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) bloc's tally drops from a peak of 234 seats in the Lok Sabha poll to 182 today, a fall of 52 seats. Another finding of this MOTN nails the underlying psychology: the top pick for the 'single biggest achievement' of the NDA is political stability, ahead of even the Ram temple and the abrogation of Article 370. Clearly, in globally uncertain times, India has reposed its trust in a leader who embodies certitude and resilience.



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That Modi has widened the gap over his rivals in the Opposition is a natural corollary. While Congress leader Rahul Gandhi's percentages also inch up across our last four biannual MOTNs: from 22.4 in 2024 to 26.6 per cent now, he mostly gains at the expense of others. Vis-à-vis Modi, the gap is intact, both statistically and perceptually. In a familiar paradox, Modi continues to fly above the noise as a singular persona, with no signs of anti-incumbency weighing him down in his 12th year as prime minister. He still enjoys an impressive 'outstanding' or 'good' verdict of 57 per cent on his prime ministerial performance. Satisfaction with the NDA government follows a similar arc with a 52.1 per cent rating. On its handling of the economy, the NDA gets 48.8 per cent voting for 'outstanding' or 'good', but future sentiment stays fragile: those expecting the economy to improve in the next six months remain stuck in the mid-30s, while 30.9 per cent fear it'll get worse. On cue, roughly six in 10 still say their current expenses are "difficult to manage".

A related set of perceptual markers also stays nearly constant: the ratio of those saying the benefits of growth go "only to the rich" is slimmer by 2.9 points at 39.6 per cent, but still way above those who think they are "reaching widely" (28 per cent). For years, over half the sample has also picked big business as the largest beneficiary of policies: it's still 53 per cent now. Yet when asked to choose an economic manager, respondents unambiguously pick Modi. The lead he had over Manmohan Singh, its lowest ever at 1.5 per cent last August, swells back to nearly 18 per cent. Foreign policy, once an unambiguous positive for Modi, now delivers less euphoric figures, but that's natural in times when a majority 53.6 per cent of respondents judge, rightly, that Indo-US ties have "worsened" in the Trump era.

Seen against this, the Opposition presents a picture of aimless drift. Rahul's claim to be its consensual face has stabilised rather than surged. Public judgement on his Lok Sabha performance is more ambivalent: 'outstanding' plus 'good' add up to only 44 per cent now, against 50.3 per cent in August. The Congress's institutional standing, too, has eroded: the MOTN tracker shows those who picked 'outstanding' or 'good' tumbling from 47.2 per cent last August to 41 per cent now, while 'poor'/'very poor' inches up to the low-30s. Asked whether the Congress is the "real Opposition party", the 'yes' camp plummets to 55 per cent from the mid-60s last year. Perhaps as damningly, 'don't know/can't say' swells to 16 per cent! Nearly 62 per cent also now describe Congress as the "weak link" of the INDIA bloc. The Bihar imprint is writ large there.

Some numbers catch the contemporary moment with drama: air pollution debuts as a top priority issue at a very high 78.8 per cent; 29 per cent fear AI will take away their job; and Madhuri Dixit leads the 1990s heroines now ruling OTT. Amitabh Bachchan and Virat Kohli still own their respective fiefdoms, of course. But the enduring finding is that Prime Minister Modi has regained his mojo in the eyes of the voter by delivering both political and economic stability in these turbulent times. The strong MOTN mandate will give more power to his elbow to carry out the big reforms needed to push economic growth in the direction of a Viksit Bharat.

(Aroon Purie)